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Newsom signs bills creating security protections for religious worshipers

September 27, 2026 | Sacramento Bee, The (CA)
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Page: 7A
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California now bans people from protesting, harassing or blocking people exiting or entering a religious facility within a certain radius, after Gov. Gavin Newsom signed two bills Friday that shore up state protections for religious worshipers.

Assembly Bill 2664 makes it illegal for a protestor who is within 100 feet of a religious facility to approach someone who is within eight feet of an entrance or exit to petition or protest the person or intentionally harass, obstruct, threaten or intimidate them. The other bill Newsom signed, Assembly Bill 1836, expands the availability of state security grants to offsite celebrations like cultural and religious festivals, marches and LGBTQ pride events.

Newsom signed AB 2264 on Friday at the Wilshire Boulevard Temple in Los Angeles, where police arrested two people last December at a demonstration outside the synagogue because the temple was hosting a private event with a speaker from Elbit Systems, the Israeli military's largest defense contractor. The protesters were criticizing Elbit for manufacturing "weapons and technology that Israel uses against Palestinian civilians" and its contracts with U.S. border security agencies.

"Every Californian should be able to walk into a synagogue, church, mosque or other house of worship without fear," Newsom said. "California is continuing to protect these organizations and the people they serve, and we're strengthening that work from the front door to expanding security resources to community events statewide."

AB 2264's sponsor, Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, D-Orinda, thanked Newsom for creating a "safe bubble zone," noting that antisemitism has risen in recent years.

"For too long, too many people have been asked to accept fear as part of practicing their faith," she said. "As a Jewish woman and a mother, I know this is not abstract - one in four Jewish Americans now says they do not feel safe attending Jewish institutions."

Newsom's signing of AB 1836 sent a "clear message that Californians of all faiths and backgrounds should be able to gather, worship and celebrate without fear," according to its sponsor, Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino. "Under Governor Newsom's leadership, California has been at the forefront of the fight against hate, and we are deeply grateful to him for signing this important new law."

The Legislative Jewish caucus, which Gabriel chairs and Bauer-Kahan is a member of, supported both bills, along with the Legislative LGBTQ caucus.

"AB 1836 strengthens California's commitment to protecting organizations and communities that too often face threats simply because of who they are or who they serve," said Assemblymember Chris Ward, D-San Diego, who chairs the LGBTQ caucus. "With Governor Newsom signing AB 1836, California is ensuring our LGBTQ+, Jewish, and other communities targeted by hate have the resources they need to gather safely and without fear."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Russell, L. (2026, September 27). Newsom signs bills creating security protections for religious worshipers.*Sacramento Bee, The (CA)*, p. 7A. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1AAE7153C65239A0.